Ambassador Holbrooke. And I would just conclude with one bleak but unavoidable conclusion I came back from this trip with. We are now in the 7th year of the war in Afghanistan. This war is going to be lot longer than the war in Iraq. It is my conclusion that the Taliban cannot win because they are basing their policies on suicide bombers and terrorism. That is not a winning strategy. We should never confuse the Taliban with the Viet Cong who it is a whole different thing.

On the other hand, the government we are supporting cannot win. It is riddled with corruption, it is weak, it is making all sorts of very unfortunate deals with the most conservative elements within Afghanistan itself, elements whose ideology is very close to the Taliban but happen to be in the Parliament. And the United States is getting deeper and deeper into a situation from which it can neither leave nor succeed in.

The theory, of course, is that as we put troops into Afghanistan they will clear out areas and then we will turn those areas over to the local military and police. But the fact is it will not happen because we are so good, for example, they just dropped 3,100 of *General Jones*' Marines right into the middle of Helmand Province in the last few weeks and they are in the process of doing it, and they are going to be fantastic. And everywhere the Marines go, and they are going to the toughest part of the country, they will clear out areas. The people will be very pleased by and large because they hate the Taliban. And the Americans will be welcomed, as they always are, for what they do. Behind them will come works: Bridges, roads, schools.

But the theory will get caught on the dilemma, Mr. Chairman, of whether or not the United States and NATO can ever turn those regions over to the local security forces. The military is not too good but slowly improving. The police, as their report said, the police are riddled with corruption. And there will be, and the military, improving though they are, are never in the foreseeable future going to be able to take over the security responsibility. We provide the logistics, the communications, a lot of the planning, the close air support. And we are efficient, we are not corrupt. And by doing all that we are running the risk of succeeding short term and creating a long-term dependency.

This is the dilemma that we must face. And that is why I conclude reluctantly that this will be ultimately the longest war in American history but, Mr. Chairman, one we must wage.

Thank you.

Chairman Berman. Well, thank you very much, Mr. Ambassador. *Ambassador Pickring*, do you have a more upbeat story to tell us?

STATEMENT OF THE HONORABLE THOMAS R. PICKERING, VICE CHAIRMAN, HILLS & COMPANY (FORMER UNITED STATES AMBASSADOR TO THE UNITED NATIONS)

Ambassador Pickring. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. Let me begin by joining Dick in his kind words about Tom Lantos whom we all admired, worked with closely, and felt the great loss that I know you and the committee share and the House shares in his absence from us all today.

Let me also say that there is indeed much of what Dick has said that I think I find myself in very broad general agreement with. Much of the predicate of that, as Dick made clear

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